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February 5, 2026

Department Letter for Hannah Widmaier's DTA Nomination

I am writing on behalf of the Philosophy Department to strongly recommend that Hannah Widmaier be considered for the University Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. Hannah is an extraordinary teacher who is praised in superlative terms in her letters. We believe she richly deserves this award. A summary of her key credentials follows:

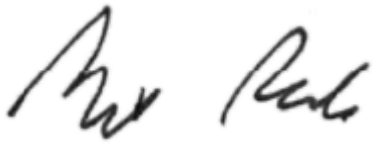
- The *eleven* courses she has taught across a wide range of subdisciplines (from Philosophy of Religion to Philosophy of Medicine), including *one* where she was entrusted as lead instructor.
- The excellent evaluation scores across all of those courses and over a healthy number of respondents (8.81 weighted average, 8.87 median).
- The qualitative testimony of students in letters and evaluation comments. These attest to (i) the *effectiveness of her teaching* ("engaging," "thorough," "shares knowledge effectively," "very well organized," "evidence-based student-centered teaching practices").
  (ii) *her ability to challenge and inspire* students at different levels of preparation and from different backgrounds ("did a great job to get the majority of the class to participate," "not afraid to be honest about feedback," "pushed us outside of our comfort zone," "made sure we accepted that even if we couldn't always perfectly articulate our ideas or thoughts, or feel 100% confident in them that that was okay"), and
  (iii) the lengths she takes to *support students and their learning* ("prepared question sheets," "extremely accommodating," "very understanding of any issues that students were facing").

On top of these things, I should also note:

- Hannah's pedagogy has already been recognized by the Department in the two formal awards we grant for teaching – both the Yost Prize for Excellence in Teaching and the Department Teaching Award.
- Hannah was selected by her peers and endorsed by the faculty to serve as Teaching Assistant Coordinator. The responsibilities of the TAC include teaching pedagogy to new TAs, helping to allocate teaching assignments among TAs, and helping TAs navigate any difficulties that arise in the course of their teaching.

Hannah has been exceptionally consistent in her excellence and earned comments like “11/10 TA” in her evaluations. She has touched the lives of those who wrote letters for her and distinguished herself as a natural leader among her peer TAs. We are proud to have her teaching for us, and we believe she also deserves the University’s recognition.

Yours faithfully,



Michael Rescorla
Chair
UCLA Department of Philosophy

Nominee Statement

During my time as a graduate student in the UCLA Philosophy Department, I have gained extensive and varied experience as an undergraduate instructor, serving as Teaching Assistant (TA) for five lower-division courses (Introduction to Philosophy of Mind, Philosophical Analysis of Contemporary Moral Issues, Introduction to Philosophy of Science, Philosophy of Death and Grief, and Introduction to Philosophy of Religion) and five upper-division courses (Metaethics: Conceptions of Good, Normative Ethics: Psychological Capacities and Moral Status, Medical Ethics, Philosophy of Law, and Philosophy of Medicine). I am grateful to have received the 2022-3 Robert M. Yost Prize for Excellence in Teaching, which the Philosophy Department awards annually for excellent performance as a TA.

During the summer of 2025, I was the lead instructor for a lower-division online summer course (Introduction to Political Philosophy), and I will teach an upper-division online summer course (Philosophy of Law) as lead instructor during the summer of 2026.

I also served as lead instructor for Philosophy 495 (Teaching College Philosophy) – a pedagogy training course for the Philosophy Department's eight first-time TAs – during the Fall 2025 quarter. I taught this course in my capacity as the 2025 Teaching Assistant Consultant (TAC) for the Philosophy Department. (I was elected to the TAC position by my fellow philosophy graduate students.) As I was designing Philosophy 495, I kept in mind that some of the most valuable growth I've experienced as a teacher has come from ongoing conversations with fellow teachers (e.g., philosophy professors and TAs) about specific, concrete questions – e.g., how most productively to challenge a certain group of students in light of their academic backgrounds and interests and how best to teach a certain difficult philosophical text. I wanted to facilitate such conversations for the first-time TAs taking Philosophy 495.

So, I designed Philosophy 495 as a seminar-style course, devoting time during each weekly meeting for the TAs to discuss their experiences and to get advice (and moral support) from me and each other about how to handle difficulties as they arose. I also devoted time each week to discussing – and having TAs practice – a number of concrete pedagogical strategies, including:

- How to craft challenging and engaging discussion prompts and other activities (e.g., close reading exercises for courses with especially difficult texts).
- How to facilitate inclusive discussions. E.g., strategies for creating a respectful classroom environment, for making quieter students feel comfortable contributing, and for making all students feel comfortable speaking up if they are confused about the material.
- How to make the best use of a classroom's physical layout. E.g., arranging tables and chairs (when possible) so that students can face each other during discussions.
- How to balance classroom time between two distinct aims – (1) reviewing material from readings and lectures, and (2) facilitating more open-ended discussion and critical engagement – in light of how difficult the material is and how clear the lectures are.

During the Week 6 meeting of Philosophy 495, I hosted two back-to-back Q&A panels (each 50 minutes long) of departmental "teaching experts"– first, a panel of experienced philosophy TAs, and second, a panel of philosophy professors – in order to give the first-time TAs the opportunity to receive teaching advice from a variety of instructors at different career stages and with different pedagogical styles and disciplinary focuses. I encouraged the first-time TAs and the panelists to continue talking and thinking together about teaching in later conversations.

I also made teaching observations a major component of Philosophy 495. I required the TAs to observe sections taught by three different TAs in the philosophy department: (i) fellow first-time TA, (ii) an experienced TA assigned to the same course as the observer, and (iii) an experienced TA assigned to a different course than the observer. I also observed each first-time TA teaching one of their discussion sections, and I held one-on-one meetings with them afterwards to provide feedback.

Throughout my work as TA, lead instructor, and TAC, I have benefited from the training I received when I completed The Discussion Project workshop (via UW-Madison), which teaches college teachers strategies for (1) facilitating rigorous, engaging, and inclusive discussions in their classes, and (2) observing and providing constructive feedback on each other's teaching. I have also gained valuable teaching and mentoring experience as a volunteer for the LA chapter of Corrupt the Youth (designing and teaching self-contained philosophy classes for high school students with little or no prior background in philosophy), and as co-advisor for the UCLA undergraduate team for the International Business Ethics and Sustainability Case Competition.

Statement of Teaching Philosophy

My approach to teaching philosophy is guided by two foundational beliefs:

1. All students have the potential to develop strong philosophical skills – and, in particular, to make valuable contributions to the joint enterprise of using philosophical tools to understand and answer difficult questions.
2. In order to develop these skills, students must actively practice them, rather than merely observing others practice them.

The philosophical skills I have in mind include the following: Analyzing and evaluating arguments in order to identify their weaknesses (if they have them) or how they work successfully (if they do); identifying patterns, drawing comparisons, and tracing common themes across multiple texts and arguments; and talking and thinking productively with others about questions that are open to reasonable disagreement.

I try to encourage growth mindset in the written feedback I provide on students' papers (see **Teaching Artifact #4**). I typically identify at least one strength of a student's paper, as well as at least one area for potential improvement. Even when a student's paper is excellent (e.g., an A or A+ paper), I will pose a question or challenge to their argument, in order to help them further develop their thinking.

I also emphasize growth mindset and active learning in my facilitation of classroom discussions. I have heard from some students – especially those taking their first philosophy course – that they find philosophy intimidating and feel anxious about their ability to make valuable contributions to class discussions. Because of this, I take deliberate steps to create a classroom environment that both challenges students to participate actively and makes students feel comfortable speaking up even when they are confused or are not confident that they have the correct answer. Here is what I usually write on my section and course syllabi about what I consider to be "good" class participation; I also say something like this to my students during our first meetings:

> *Good participation in class requires doing the assigned reading ahead of time and thinking through your thoughts and questions about it. To participate well, you do not need to talk all the time or avoid making mistakes when you do talk. In fact, <u>making mistakes</u> during a philosophy discussion can be a sign that you are engaging deeply with the material, and mistakes are a good opportunity to improve your understanding. You should help facilitate a respectful and collaborative discussion environment, listen carefully to your classmates' points, and to work with each other to develop your thinking. Look at whoever is talking, and address people by name when responding to them. <u>Disagreeing</u> with each other about philosophical questions is valuable and can spark great discussions; make sure to direct your criticism at the substance of an argument or view, not at the person defending it.*
>
> *I will sometimes call on people who do not have their hands raised. I do this to make sure you all have a chance to contribute and to learn from each other's contributions. It's always ok to say that you'd like to pass when I call on you.*

In emphasizing to my students that it is not only acceptable, but positively valuable, to make mistakes when working through a philosophical puzzle with others, I am laying a foundation for class discussions that are both intellectually rigorous and "safe," in the sense that students know they will not be shamed or treated dismissively for making mistakes or voicing confusion. The feedback I received on my Student Experiences of Teaching (SET) surveys (see **Teaching Artifact #1**) provides some evidence that I am

successfully achieving this aim; many students express that they feel both comfortable participating in my class discussions and eager to do so, since the discussions are interesting and engaging.

For each class meeting, I prepare a handout, of which I distribute printed copies to all students at the beginning of the meeting. (See **Teaching Artifact #5** for an example.) The handout typically focuses on the week's assigned reading but does not simply summarize all of the reading's main points. Rather, I write some comprehension-focused questions that prompt students to recall and summarize the reading's main points (see, e.g., the "small group activity" from **Teaching Artifact #5**). I sometimes also include a close reading exercise, in which I have students re-read a short excerpt from the assigned reading and work in pairs or small groups to re-state the excerpt's most important points in their own words. Students have told me that these close reading exercises are particularly helpful as preparation for writing papers and exams. On the handout, I also include some questions that are not focused on reading comprehension but instead challenge students to engage in original philosophical thinking of their own: e.g., to critically evaluate the arguments presented in the reading or to construct their own arguments about the relevant question(s). (See, e.g., the final two "discussion questions" from **Teaching Artifact #5**.)

I was the lead instructor Philosophy 6 (Introduction to Political Philosophy) and therefore had more control over the overall course structure. In addition to facilitating class discussions in which I prompted students to engage actively with each other's questions and perspectives, I required the students to write weekly posts about the assigned reading on an online discussion board, via the course's Bruin Learn site, and to respond to one of their classmates' posts each week (see **Teaching Artifact #2**.) This discussion post assignment prompted students to engage more deeply with the assigned readings. It also proved invaluable as I prepared class discussions; I often invited students to elaborate (during our meetings) on a point or question they had raised in their online posts, and students would sometimes draw on their classmates' posts during our meetings. I also offered students the opportunity to write co-authored papers in "dialogue" form (see **Teaching Artifact #3**), so as to further hone their skills of cooperative shared inquiry.

Teaching Artifact #1: A selection of comments (unedited) from Student Experiences of Teaching (SET) surveys for multiple UCLA courses for which I've served as Teaching Assistant. Complete SET surveys available upon request.

Philosophy 153A (Normative Ethics: Moral Status and Psychological Capacities), Spring 2023

* This is my favorite class I have ever taken at UCLA! Both the professor and section leader are fantastic. I regret not going to office hours more and talking to them more because I feel like they were both equally knowledgable and visiting either one for questions in office hours would be equally beneficial. Hannah is genuinely the most prepared TA I have ever had. She comes with her document ready by the start of class every time--it's very organized and explains the argument in a way that both philosophy and non-philosophy majors can understand. She includes quotes in the section docs which are very helpful for my learning. She encourages each one of us to talk, at least in an icebreaker, every class. This is something I struggle with so I really appreciate it. I don't love participating in small groups, but I know it's good for my growth. So I actually love how we do that in small quantities and then turn and share what we spoke about in the class. When TAs allow small student-to-student work to go for the whole class, I am usually guilty of not getting anything done. So I think the way Hannah divides her section into both student conversation with each other, student conversation with the TA, and her teaching is extremely balanced, well-rounded, and efficient. I also really enjoyed the Socratic seminar class and would love to do more of those. I love the amount of student voices we get to hear and Hannah's teaching--balanced. Hannah is very approachable, cares about her students and learning their names, responds over email, and cares about helping us improve. Thank you Hannah for an awesome quarter!

Philosophy 155A (Medical Ethics), Summer 2023

* Hannah has been a great assistant and supporter. Discussion for Medical Ethics was always fun and engaging, to be able to participate in a class full of other students with opinions of their own in a space provided by Hannah. The space was always free of judgment and full of support. I think this is important because as someone who came in knowing almost nothing about medical ethics, I was often intimidated about saying the wrong things, but because Hannah took time to break down and reword or clarify what we meant, that made asking and participating in discussion less intimidating. Hannah's patience and detailed planning also meant the discussion went by too fast with all the comments and activities we as a class participated in. One discussion class that I found helpful was a writing shop, this is different and so helpful in my time as a philosophy major. This made writing my philosophy paper less frustrating and understandable since the activity focused on easing our confusion and stress. Overall, Hannah really cared about our understanding of the class and made us all comfortable to voice our opinions.

* Hannah was possibly the best TA I have ever had and I would be beyond ecstatic if she could be my TA for every class. Her discussion sections made all the information make much more sense and she really got everyone involved to get a fluid discussion going. She was always encouraging us to go to her for questions and never once gave a response that I was confused about or wasn't satisfied with. She knows what she is talking about at all times and never makes class feel dull. She made very helpful handouts that led the students to understand the messages of the topics we were learning. Not only her teaching ability, but she was also just an amazing human who was very kind and always wanted the best for us.

* I have had Hannah in the past as a TA and she is primarily the main reason I took this course during the summer. As a TA, she integrates lecture material insanely well that it is always a perfect transition into lecture. Her strengths fall in line with her extremely personable personality and teaching style, and she welcomes all students to participate in a non-stressful manner. She always provides handouts which help us stay engaged with discussion as opposed to strenuous note taking which is how she stands out from other TAs. She is the best TA I have had at my time at UCLA.

Philosophy 166 (Philosophy of Law), Summer 2024 – *Online (Zoom) course*

* I really enjoyed section with Hannah. She was extremely helpful in helping explain complex texts that we read in the course, along with providing assistance with assignment requirements. The discussion handouts were particularly helpful to refer to and the breakout rooms were great for helping us engage with the text, particularly since its a philosophy class. Hannah's sections were my favorite discussion section I have had at UCLA thus far, and by far the most beneficial and worth the time.

Philosophy 10 (Philosophy of Death and Grief), Fall 2024

* Being part of Hannah's class has been a fantastic experience. Her dedication to her students and passion for teaching are clear in everything she does. I especially appreciated her approach to office hours, where she fostered a collaborative environment. The group format not only allowed us to ask her questions directly but also encouraged productive discussions with fellow students. This setup helped me deepen my understanding of the material, and I was able to apply what I learned during exams. Hannah Widmaier is an excellent teacher, and I hope to take another class with her in the future.

Philosophy 2 (Introduction to Philosophy of Religion), Winter 2025

* I think Hannah was a really good TA. She was very knowledgeable in the topic and that made learning from her a lot easier. She constantly allowed for open discussion and encouraged everyone to share their ideas. I liked how she would use our ideas and comments to keep the conversation flowing and would always help us clarify our ideas more. I found it very easy to go to her for help and she was really understanding. Hannah really cared about the well–being of her students and she definitely contributed to enjoyment of the class. I also found that she was very useful when studying for the midterm. She wouldn't just give answers but guide us to get there. if there was something that was unclear in during the midterm review, she made sure to clarify it.

* Ms. Widmaier has been my favorite TA so far. She was not only incredibly kind and understanding but also ensured that discussions were very welcoming and inviting space to speak up. She ensured that all students felt heard and respected and was always open to answering any questions we may have had. She is very knowledgeable about the subject and still was able to explain topics in a manner easy to understand as beginners to the subject. I greatly looked forward to attending discussions each week and always walked out feeling like I had a better understanding than I did prior to the discussion. Sections were always well structured and engaging, inviting participation from myself and my peers while still providing her own deeper analysis of the topics. I am so grateful for the time and effort she clearly puts into helping her students and furthering their success.

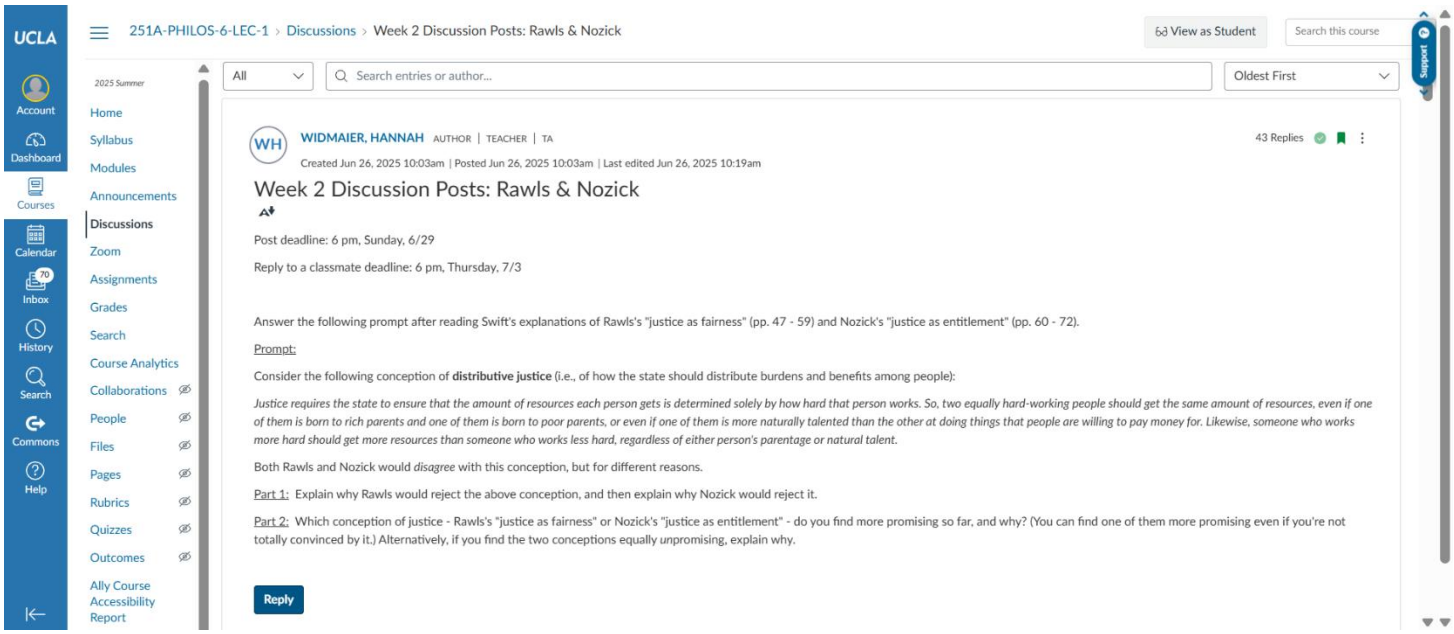
Philosophy 173 (Philosophy of Medicine), Spring 2025

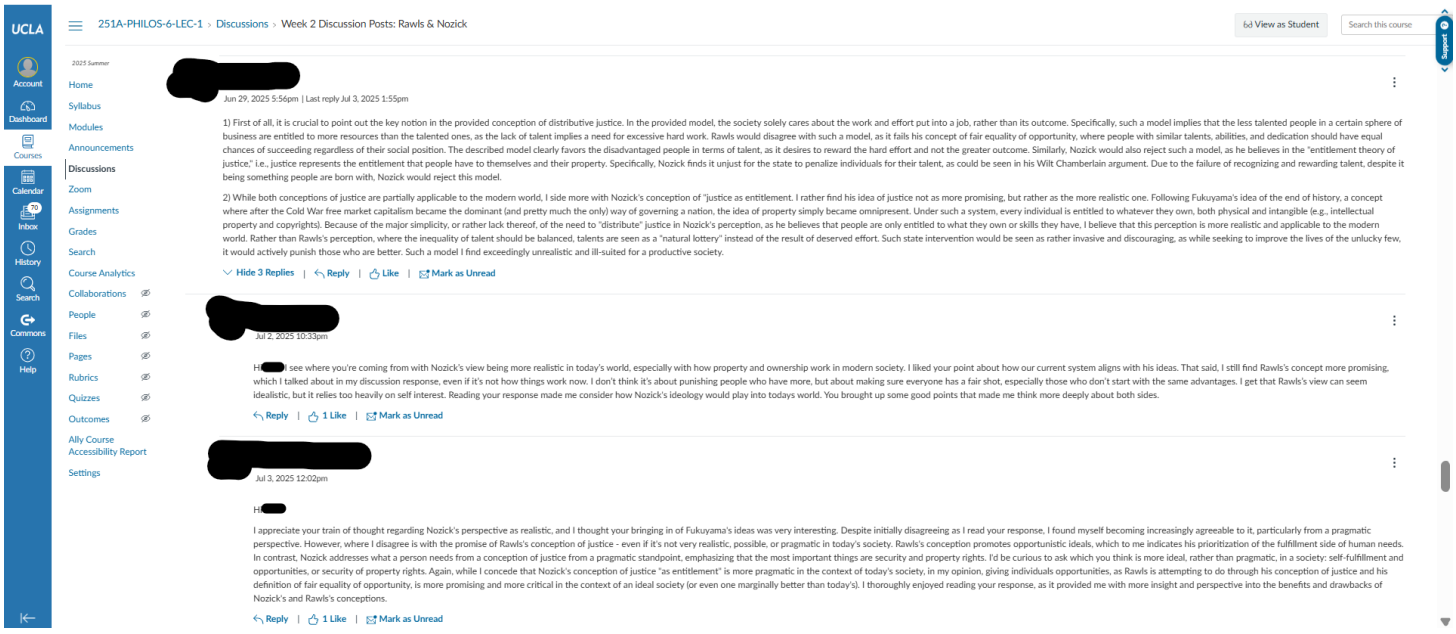
* Hannah is the best instructor I've had at UCLA—including professors. It is clear that she puts a lot of thought into her teaching, and it has really helped with my understanding of the material. She has a clear structure to her sections and budgets time to cover each paper from that week. She prioritizes incorporating our questions and is quick to adjust her section plans to discuss what is most helpful to us. She explains concepts clearly, and there has never been a question she has not been able to answer. She has honestly made me enjoy learning again and I cannot recommend Hannah more as a TA.

* I cannot say enough positive things about Hannah as the TA for this course. She was truly outstanding—kind, knowledgeable, and always willing to help. From the very beginning, it was clear that she cared deeply about making the material accessible and creating a welcoming learning environment for all students. One of her greatest strengths was her ability to explain complex philosophical arguments in a clear and straightforward way, without ever dumbing anything down or making anyone feel inferior for asking basic questions. She communicated effectively, encouraged open dialogue during discussion sections, and was incredibly responsive to questions both in and outside of class. She consistently held her office hours and made herself fully available to support students, which I personally appreciated and took advantage of throughout the course. What made her especially effective was her flexibility and student–centered approach. She was always willing to adjust discussion plans based on what the class needed most, rather than sticking rigidly to a predetermined outline. This made sections feel relevant, tailored, and much more engaging. She kept things fresh, switched up activities, and regularly checked in to see how she could better support us. Even though I didn't end up going to the professor's office hours, I never felt lost because Hannah provided such strong support and clarity. Honestly, she played a huge role in making this class one of the best I've taken at UCLA. Overall, I feel incredibly lucky to have had such a thoughtful and dedicated TA. She made a real impact on my learning experience, and I would enthusiastically recommend her to any future students.

* Hannah is one of the best TAs I've had at UCLA. She's incredibly sharp, articulate, and has a real talent for making complex material clear and engaging. Her deep understanding of the subject matter is evident in the way she leads discussion; she's able to break down difficult concepts without oversimplifying them, and she encourages thoughtful participation from everyone. She also brings a great sense of humor and energy to her teaching, which makes her sections not only informative but genuinely enjoyable. It's clear she puts a lot of thought into how she teaches, and her ability to explain ideas in a way that sticks has had a lasting impact on my understanding of the course material.

Teaching Artifact #2: Screenshots of the Bruin Learn site for Philosophy 6 (Introduction to Political Philosophy), which I taught as lead instructor during the summer of 2025. The first screenshot shows the instructions and prompt I wrote for one of the required weekly online discussion posts. The second screenshot shows a post, responding to my prompt, by one of the students, followed by replies from two of their classmates. I've redacted the three students' names to protect their privacy.





Teaching Artifact #3: Instructions and prompts I wrote for students' final papers for Philosophy 6 (Introduction to Political Philosophy), which I taught as lead instructor during the summer of 2025.

Total points available: 35 (i.e., 35% of overall course grade)
Length requirement: 1600-2400 words for individually authored papers
3200-4800 words for co-authored papers (more details below)
Format requirement: Please submit your paper as a Word document.

Your paper may discuss one (or more) of the following readings:

- Angela Davis (2003), *Are Prisons Obsolete?* "Slavery, Civil Rights, and Abolitionist Perspectives Toward Prison," pp. 22 - 39
- Tommie Shelby (2022), *The Idea of Prison Abolition,* "A Broken System? Racism and Functional Critique," pp. 87 - 119
    - If you select the above Shelby chapter, you may (but need not) *also* discuss the introduction of Shelby's book: "Introduction: Reform or Abolition?" pp. 1 - 8 and pp. 15 - 17
- Gina Schouten (2019), Liberalism, Neutrality, and the Gendered Division of Labor, "A Stalled Revolution and the Gender-Egalitarian Policy Agenda," pp. 31 - 62
- Gina Schouten (2019), "'Flexible' Family Leave is Lousy Feminism," Boston Review https://www.bostonreview.net/articles/gina-schouten-case-inexible-family-support/
- Anca Gheaus (2020), "The Feminist Argument Against Supporting Care," pp. 87 - 113
- Jeremy Waldron (1991), "Homelessness and the Issue of Freedom," pp. 295 - 324
- Christopher Essert (2016), "Property and Homelessness," pp. 266 – 295

You may (but need not) write a co-authored, "conversation" paper with one of your classmates, instead of an individually authored paper. These co-authored papers should be 3200-4800 words long and should take the form of a back-and-forth dialogue, in which each author contributes roughly equally and puts their name next to the passages they wrote. My default approach will be to give both authors the same paper grade. If you and a classmate write a co-authored paper, you should both submit the paper as a Word document in the assignment submission portal.

You have two different options for how to structure your paper:
Option #1:
Select one of the above philosophers to respond to.

a. Explain a particular claim or distinction the philosopher makes, and explain what role that claim or distinction makes in the philosopher's overall view.
b. Offer a criticism to the claim or distinction you explained in part (a). You do not have to agree with the objection; just offer a criticism that a reasonable and thoughtful reader might make. The objection may (but need not) be inspired by a different philosopher we have read (e.g., you might draw on Gheaus to criticize Schouten, or vice versa); if so, you should cite the other philosopher as well.
c. Explain whether you think the criticism from part (b) is successful or not. If it is, what implication does that have for the philosopher's overall view?

Option #2:
Select one of the above philosophers to respond to.

a. Identify and explain a current *social or legal practice* to which the philosopher's argument is relevant. E.g., you might discuss some aspect of the U.S.'s criminal justice system in connection with Davis or Shelby; you might discuss some aspect of homeless people's experience in connection with Waldron or Essert; you might discuss some pervasive gender norm or some structural aspect of the workplace in connection with Schouten or Gheaus.
b. Explain how the philosopher you selected might *evaluate* the social or legal practice that you presented in part (a). Support your explanation by citing textual evidence from the chapter or article we read by that author. Here, you are attributing a *particular view* to that author.
c. Offer a *critical response* to the philosopher's view that you explained in part (b). This response may take one of the following forms:
    i. Present an objection to the philosopher's view, and argue that that objection succeeds (explain why).
    ii. Present an objection to the philosopher's view, and argue that that objection fails (explain why).

Teaching Artifact #4: A sample of the written comments I gave students on their final papers for Philosophy 153A (Normative Ethics: Moral Status and Psychological Capacities), for which I served as TA in the spring of 2023. Students in this course had the opportunity to expand and revise their midterm papers, in light of my feedback, and submit the revised versions as their final papers. So, some of my feedback below refers to students' development of their ideas from earlier papers.

Comments on Student X's final paper:

Again, terrific work: a careful, thoughtful, and interesting discussion of Kant on animals and AI. You start with an exceptionally clear and thorough explanation of Kant's account of rationality and moral status and use this explanation to make a convincing argument against Korsgaard's interpretation of Kant. I raised some substantive questions in this section about when something counts as a source of legitimate normative claims. I think we disagree on this question – e.g., I suspect that the car cannot be a source of normative claims even when you confer value on it – but I mean this as a question open to real disagreement (maybe you have an interpretation of Kant that would resolve my worry?).

Your new section on AI is great. Especial strengths:

1. Well-chosen examples to illustrate your points.
2. You carefully distinguish between what AI systems happen to be like right now, and what they could potentially be like if developed in a certain way; this is crucial for clarifying the focus of your question about Kantian moral status.
3. When considering whether AI has or could have the capacities necessary for Kantian rationality, you do a nice job of distinguishing between (i) basic intelligence / reasoning / learning capacities, (ii) the ability to be an authoritative reasoner, and (iii) the ability to represent oneself to oneself as an authoritative reasoner. It's a good strategy to discuss each of these capacities, at length, one at a time.

Aside from the question I raised about the moral relevance of having a physical body and perceptual capacities, you might think more about the questions relating to consciousness that you raise on pp. 10 – 11: (i) whether something must be conscious (not just self-aware) in order to be a Kantian end-in-itself, and (ii) what it means for something to be conscious. To these, I'd add: (iii) what you think the difference is between self-awareness and consciousness. If you want to develop the consciousness discussion, you might take a look at some philosophy of mind literature. SEP (always a good resource) has a helpful entry, which mentions some of Kant's own views on consciousness: https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/consciousness/

And, as we discussed, you might also think about non-Kantian accounts of moral status and whether they apply to AI systems. Happy to talk about this as you continue to work on it.

- Hannah

Comments on Student Y's final paper:

Great work. You continue to clearly map the connections between Singer's claims (e.g., by showing how he derives his argument for vegetarianism from his PEC and his view that animals have moral status), and you're nicely specific about what his view does and doesn't imply (e.g., by distinguishing his claim that it's wrong to support the meat industry from the different claim that the act of eating meat itself causes suffering).

Starting on p. 4, you raise a series of important objections to your criticism of Singer's argument; you articulate these objections carefully and offer thoughtful replies to them. A particular strength: This section is not just a laundry list of disconnected objections. Rather, you structure the discussion as a conversation that you might have with Singer, showing how your reply to one objection might inspire him to raise a new but related objection. This back-and-forth is great and makes your discussion unified and enjoyable to read.
Here's a substantive topic you might continue to think about:

In response to the objection you raise on p. 5, viz., that purchasing meat is immoral (according to Singer's utilitarianism) because it helps sustain cruel animal farming practices, you argue that because you did not create the practices and you are not the cause of animal suffering, you "do not have a direct responsibility to correct the injustice" of farms' mistreatment of animals.

Let's put aside the complicated empirical question of whether you really do causally contribute to animal suffering by purchasing meat (you thoughtfully address this in later paragraphs), and just focus on the moral question of whether, in general, we have an obligation to help rectify moral wrongs that we did not cause in the first place. It seems to me that Singer's utilitarian view – especially the greatest happiness principle / principle of maximization – says that we do have this obligation. The GHP says that an action is right to the extent that it results in greater total happiness than alternative actions (and wrong to the extent that it fails to do this). Notice that this principle does not let you off the hook for rectifying wrongs that you didn't perpetrate. The focus is just on *consequences*: Will eliminating (or mitigating) this suffering help maximize overall happiness? If so, then you should try to eliminate or mitigate it, whether or not you caused the suffering in the first place. And importantly, when the utilitarian says that you have this obligation, they're not implying that you caused the suffering. It's helpful to distinguish two different senses of "responsibility" that I think you conflate on p. 5:

(i) P *caused* X;
(ii) (ii) P has a *duty to eliminate or mitigate* X.

It's not obvious that (i) is required for (ii), and a utilitarian like Singer would say that (i) is *definitely not* required for (ii). So, your reply to the p. 5 objection is best thought of as a rejection of utilitarianism (including GHP) altogether, rather than a disagreement with how Singer interprets GHP. More generally, it might be interesting to think more about the connection between (i) and (ii). What substantive reasons can you give for your view that (i) is required for (ii)? What objections can you anticipate to this view?

Again, great work – this was a very interesting and enjoyable read!

- Hannah

Comments on Student Z's paper:

Again, great work in this paper. You thoroughly reconstruct Kant's arguments that animals are not ends in themselves and that we don't have direct duties to them, carefully explaining key terms and concepts along the way; you use the well-chosen example of bees to argue that Kant is wrong to deny that all animals have rationality; and you significantly expand on your last paper by addressing the objection that bees' coordinated, self-preserving behavior might be instinctual rather than conscious and rational.

Your response to this objection is strong and interesting, and I want to leave you with some further questions to think about:

1) Your reference to "moral imagination" is intriguing, but I could have used more explanation of what you mean by this. Is moral imagination the process by which we deliberate about which course of action is morally right or wrong? What evidence do your examples give us for *moral* imagination in animals rather than some other (e.g., merely visual/spatial) sort of imagination?

2) A related question: I really like the examples of sophisticated and/or social behaviors – viz., learning, communication, problem-solving, and long-term relationships in bees and chimpanzees – that you gave in response to the above objection. These examples help build a compelling case that some animals' behaviors are sometimes rational (in the Kantian sense), not just instinctual. But when you claim that these behaviors demonstrate that bees and chimpanzees consciously think about which choices are "right" and "wrong," I'm left wondering: Do you mean right / wrong in a *moral* sense, or merely in an *instrumental* sense? (E.g.: Reaching across the table is an *instrumentally* right decision for my goal of reaching the salt shaker, but helping my friend in trouble is a *morally* right decision.) I think you've given good evidence that bees and chimpanzees can judge between instrumentally right and wrong decisions – i.e., between decisions that will or won't advance their goals – but does it follow that they can distinguish between morally right and wrong actions? This is not meant to be rhetorical: Maybe they can! But I still think more of a case is needed, because Kantian rationality crucially requires the ability to deliberate about the morally right course of action. I mean this just as something to continue thinking about, not as a criticism, since your space in this paper was limited and you've already done a lot of good work in it.

- Hannah

Teaching Artifact #5: The handout that I wrote and used in my discussion sections during Week 1 of Philosophy 173 (Philosophy of Medicine), for which I served as TA in the spring of 2025. I distributed hard copies of this handout to all my students; this is my typical practice.

Phil 173, Dis 1C & 1D *Week 1: Concepts of Health & Disease: Naturalism*

Reading: Christopher Boorse (1977), "Health as a theoretical concept"

Main questions: How should we define health and disease?

Recall from lecture: We want definitions that:

(1) classify cases correctly,
(2) tell us what "health" and "disease" mean, and
(3) *explain* the concepts of health and disease.

Clarifying terms: Boorse distinguishes between **theoretical health**, i.e., "the absence of disease," and **practical health**, i.e., "the absence of treatable illness" (542).

- NOTE: In the main part of his argument, when Boorse uses the term "health," he's referring to **theoretical health**, i.e., the absence of disease.

Small group activity: Boorse considers and rejects the following seven candidate definitions of health/disease, arguing that they fail to identify a criterion or set of criteria that is both necessary and sufficient for health; likewise, they fail to identify necessary and sufficient criteria for disease. *Briefly explain Boorse's objections to the candidate definition that is assigned to your group. Illustrate the objections with counterexamples (either Boorse's or your own).*

1. Health is physical well-being or welfare; disease is a physical condition that impedes well-being.

2. Health is the absence of a physical condition that physicians treat or that falls within medical practice; disease is a physical condition that physicians do treat or that does fall within medical practice.

3. Health is statistical normality in one's physical state; disease is statistical abnormality.

4. Health is the absence of physical pain and suffering; disease is a physical condition that causes physical pain and suffering.

5. Health is the absence of tendency to disability; disease is a physical condition that tends to cause disability.

6. Health is being adapted to one's environment; disease is a lack of adaptation to one's environment.

7. Health is equilibrium in one's physiological processes; disease is disequilibrium in one's physiological processes.

Boorse summarizes his Bio-Statistical Theory (BST) of health and disease on pp. 555 and 562. Fill in the definition of each of the four components:

1. The reference class for making judgments of health and disease is:

2. A normal function of a part or process within members of the reference class is:

3. Health in a member of the reference class is:

4. A disease in a member of the reference class is:

Discussion Question #1: What does Boorse mean when he says the BST value-free, i.e., non-evaluative?

Discussion Question #2: How might someone *challenge* Boorse's claim that the BST is value-free – i.e., how might they argue the BST includes or relies on some *evaluative* claim(s)? NOTE: It's worth writing out possible objections even if you don't end up agreeing with them – i.e., even if you ultimately think that the BST *is* value-free.

Discussion Question #3: Do you think any of the challenges you listed above successfully show that the BST is value-laden (contrary to what Boorse says)? Why or why not?

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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February 5, 2026

Dear Academic Senate Committee on Teaching,

I am writing to recommend Hannah Widmaier for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award. I do not need to gild the lily. Hannah is the most serious and talented graduate student teacher of philosophy that I have worked with. It is difficult for me to imagine someone more qualified for a distinguished recognition for their teaching.

I first worked with Hannah as a TA in my undergraduate course on death and grief, in Fall 2024. Philosophy is best taught in a conversational mode, which brings certain challenges: one must structure discussion while also allowing for it to flow freely; to do that, one must master the material, get to know one's students, and be able to both predict and improvise with them. Hannah met this challenge easily – indeed, she clearly loved it, and thrives in it. In a discussion section of hers that I observed, she broke students into small groups and gave them questions which led them in a natural but directed way through the material. She knew their names and had already worked to have rapport with them as individuals. She would occasionally intersperse their discussion with small reminders from the material as I had presented it in lecture, but never in a way that disrupted this natural, conversational but structured feel to the classroom.

This comes easily to her partly because she is a natural and unassuming leader: she takes her responsibilities and duties seriously, and her students and colleagues trust her immensely. Her sense of her responsibility extends beyond the classroom. She was the more senior of two TAs I worked with, and clearly and quickly became someone the more junior TA could rely on for understanding both the material and mechanics of the course, as well as someone to turn to for advice more generally. This is, I've since learned, a common experience for those who've worked with her. She has also flourished in her role working with me (as the departments Teaching Assistant Advisor) as our department's TAC, in both taking the lead in leading our department's course on pedagogy and in being a mentor and advisor for all of our TAs. As just one further example of her leadership: as the TAC program is now being centralized, the department wanted to think about what we can do to support our TAs in their teaching of philosophy, in particular. She attended several meetings with me and our chair, was creative in thinking of how to do this, and provided crucial detail we needed in order to understand better the nature of the position. We could not have done this without her.

Upon learning that she would be nominated by the department for this award, my colleague Paul Taylor wrote to me: "She may be the best TA I've ever worked with in almost thirty years of teaching at R1 institutions." While I do not yet have the experience of my colleague, I share his judgment that

Hannah is, quite simply, a rare bird. The department, our undergrads, and UCLA are lucky to have her.

Best wishes,



Vida Yao
Associate Professor
Department of Philosophy, UCLA